

Driverless Taxi Cameras Raise Questions About Rider Privacy

From: Wired Gear Mined: 2026-10-03 3 min read

A taxi without a driver may still have someone checking what happens inside. Companies including Waymo, Zoox and Tesla use cameras in their driverless taxis, sometimes called **robotaxis**.

Outside cameras help these cars notice the road around them. Inside cameras serve different purposes. Companies say they help keep riders safe, check that **passengers** follow rules, find lost items and check whether a car needs cleaning.

Waymo says it uses automatic technology to help staff spot possible rule **violations**. Human workers have also used the car's speaker system to check whether **passengers** were old enough to ride alone.

Zoox says its inside cameras record the whole ride. Its policies allow personal information to help run rides and improve its service. Tesla's documents say a green sign appears on the car's screen when its camera is active. Riders can choose to share inside video and sound through an app setting. The documents say early access riders automatically agree to sharing. Tesla did not tell WIRED whether that program had ended.

The companies say workers view camera **footage** only when needed. They also say personal information may be given to police or regulators.

Privacy means having some control over personal information. **Privacy** experts say few clear US rules govern this kind of **monitoring**. Matthew Guariglia of the Electronic Frontier Foundation is concerned about how much information companies collect and what happens to it afterward.

Word Treasure

robotaxis -- Taxis that drive without a human driver.

passengers -- People traveling in a vehicle.

violations -- Actions that break rules.

footage -- Video recorded by a camera.

Privacy -- Having some control over personal information.

monitoring -- Watching or checking what happens.

Background you need

Robotaxis are driverless taxis. Their outside cameras help them notice the road. Recording a ride and having a worker view it are different actions. The article describes both.

Break it down

Introduces driverless taxis and their cameras.
Explains the different purposes of outside and inside cameras.
Describes Waymo, Zoox and Tesla practices.
Explains information sharing and privacy concerns.

Why it matters

Passengers may share personal information during a ride. Knowing how cameras work helps them understand questions about who can view or use that information.

Test what you remember

1. What do outside cameras help robotaxis notice?
 - (A) The road around them
 - (B) The riders beside them
 - (C) The belongings inside them
 - (D) The seats within them
2. Why have Waymo workers used the car's speaker system?
 - (A) To explain passengers' bills
 - (B) To check passengers' ages
 - (C) To announce passengers' arrival
 - (D) To ask about passengers' destinations
3. What does Zoox say its inside cameras record?
 - (A) The whole ride
 - (B) Only the ride's beginning
 - (C) Only the ride's ending
 - (D) The time between rides
4. What do Tesla's documents say appears when the camera is active?
 - (A) A red mark on the seat
 - (B) A blue light on the door
 - (C) A yellow notice in the app
 - (D) A green sign on the screen
5. When do the companies say workers view camera footage?
 - (A) Before every booking
 - (B) Only when needed
 - (C) Throughout every ride
 - (D) After every stop
6. What concern does Matthew Guariglia raise?
 - (A) How companies collect information and use it
 - (B) How passengers book rides and pay fares
 - (C) How workers clean cars and find belongings
 - (D) How cars choose routes and avoid traffic

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: A 4: D 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Matthew Guariglia: He is concerned about how much information companies collect and what they do with it afterward.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):